Limits of functions

Lecture and worked examples

Maths Explorer

Objectives

Compute limits at a point and at infinity; resolve an indeterminate form; interpret an asymptote.

Meaning of a limit

$f(x) \to \ell$ as $x \to +\infty$ means that $f(x)$ can be made as close as desired to ℓ for all sufficiently large x. For a limit at a, we consider values of x in the domain, close to a and different from a. Left-hand and right-hand limits are written $\lim_{x \to a^-} f(x)$ and $\lim_{x \to a^+} f(x)$. When the domain contains points on both sides of a, a two-sided limit exists if and only if both one-sided limits exist and are equal. At an endpoint of the domain, we study the limit from the only accessible side.

Meaning of a limit

If $f(x) \to \ell \in \mathbb{R}$ as $x \to +\infty$ or $-\infty$, the line $y = \ell$ is a horizontal asymptote in that direction. If $f(x) \to \pm\infty$ as $x \to a$ from one side, the line $x = a$ is a vertical asymptote.

Meaning of a limit

A curve may cross a horizontal asymptote. The limit does not necessarily give the position of the curve relative to the asymptote: study the sign of $f(x) - \ell$.

Standard limits and operations

At $+\infty$, $x^m \to +\infty$ for $m \geq 1$, $\dfrac{1}{x^m} \to 0$, $\sqrt{x} \to +\infty$. At $-\infty$, the sign of x^m depends on the parity of m. The rules for sums, products, quotients and comparison are those for sequences, with the same indeterminate forms.

Standard limits and operations

For $f(x) = \dfrac{2x+1}{x-3}$, write $f(x) = 2 + \dfrac{7}{x-3}$. The limits at $\pm\infty$ equal 2. At 3^-, $f \to -\infty$; at 3^+, $f \to +\infty$. The asymptotes are $x = 3$ and $y = 2$.

Standard limits and operations

For $x > 0$, $\sqrt{x^2 + 4x} - x = \dfrac{4}{\sqrt{1 + \dfrac{4}{x}} + 1} \to 2$. For $x < 0$, be careful: $\sqrt{x^2} = |x| = -x$.

Exponential and comparison of growth rates

$$\lim_{x\to+\infty} e^x = +\infty, \qquad \lim_{x\to-\infty} e^x = 0, \qquad \lim_{x\to+\infty} \frac{e^x}{x^m} = +\infty \quad (m \in \mathbb{N}).$$

We deduce $x^m e^{-x} \to 0$ at $+\infty$.

Exponential and comparison of growth rates

Studying $e^x - x - 1$ gives $e^x \geq 1 + x$. By comparison, $e^x \to +\infty$ at $+\infty$. Setting $t = -x \to +\infty$, $e^x = \dfrac{1}{e^t} \to 0$.

Exponential and comparison of growth rates

For every integer $k \geq 0$ and $x \geq 0$, $e^x \geq \frac{x^k}{k!}$. For $k = 0$, $e^x \geq 1$. If the inequality holds at order k, the derivative of $e^x - \frac{x^{k+1}}{(k+1)!}$ is $e^x - \frac{x^k}{k!} \geq 0$; its value at 0 is positive. The inductive step follows. Choosing $k = m + 1$, $\frac{e^x}{x^m} \geq \frac{x}{(m+1)!} \to +\infty$.

Exponential and comparison of growth rates

Quotient of polynomials: factorise the highest powers. Difference of roots: conjugate expression. Quotient near a zero: factorise and study the signs. Exponential against power: comparison of growth rates, after a change of variable if necessary.

Comparison and composition: conditions of use

If $g(x) \leq f(x) \leq h(x)$ near the point or the infinity under study, and if g, h have the same real limit ℓ, then $f(x) \to \ell$ (squeeze theorem). If $g \leq f$ and $g \to +\infty$, then $f \to +\infty$. For a limit of $-\infty$, we use an upper bound by a function tending to $-\infty$. If $u(x) \to a$ and v is continuous at a, then $v(u(x)) \to v(a)$, whenever the composite is defined. For example $\sqrt{1 + \dfrac{1}{x}} \to 1$ at $+\infty$. For an infinite limit of the outer function, check from which side $u(x)$ approaches the bound: $\dfrac{1}{u(x)}$ does not behave the same way depending on the sign of $u(x)$.

Research activity

A curve close to a line - 30 min.

Consider the function f defined on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{1\}$ by $f(x) = \dfrac{3x-2}{x-1}$. Let $\mathcal{C}_f$ be its curve in a frame of the plane.

Research activity (2)

1. Show that, for every $x \neq 1$, $f(x) = 3 + \dfrac{1}{x-1}$.
2. Determine the limits of f at $-\infty$, at 1^-, at 1^+ and at $+\infty$.
3. Study the sign of $f(x) - 3$, then state the position of $\mathcal{C}_f$ relative to the line with equation $y = 3$.
4. Find a real number $A > 1$ such that, for every $x > A$, $|f(x) - 3| < 0.01$.

Research activity (3)

5. Does the curve $\mathcal{C}_f$ cross its horizontal asymptote? Justify, and explain why a graphing window that is too wide can give a misleading impression.